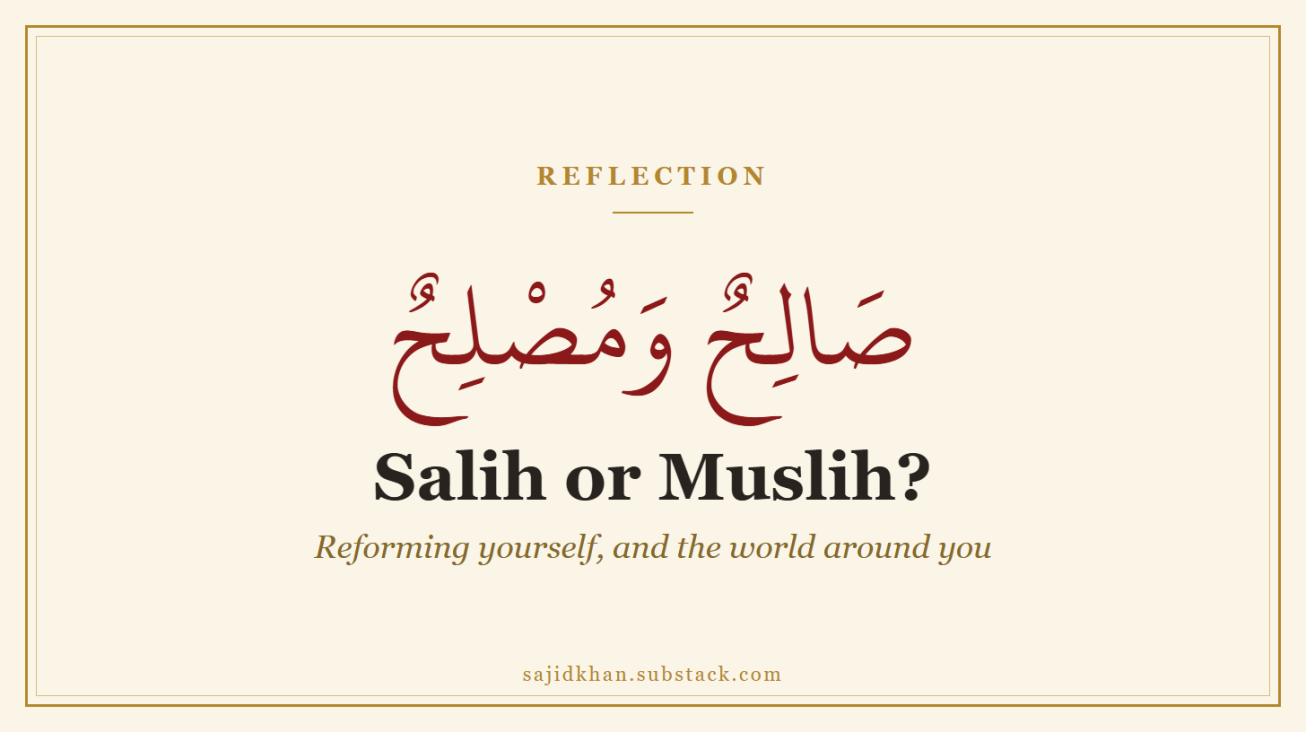


REFLECTION

Salih or Muslih?

Reforming yourself, and reforming the world around you

Scholars often say: be *saalih* (صَالِح, "righteous") and be *muslih* (مُصْلِح, "one who sets things right"). Both words come from the same root, ص ل ح, "to be sound, to be good", but there is a big difference between them.

The salih

The *saalih* reforms himself: prayer, fasting, dhikr, reading the Qur'an. Nobody has a problem with such a person. Nobody minds how many rak'aat you pray or how much dhikr you do.

The muslih

The *muslih* reforms society. He speaks against what is wrong around him. That is when the opposition starts.

Before revelation, the Prophet ﷺ was known as honest and good, and everyone in Makkah loved him, even the idol worshippers. When he was commanded to rise and warn, he spoke openly

against idol worship, against burying daughters alive, against tribal pride and the oppression of the weak. Then came the insults, the boycott, the wars.

The lesson

People will not mind you as long as you are only *saalih*. They will mind when you become *muslih*. Be ready for that, and do not let it stop you. Allah promises:

أَنِّي لَا أُضِيعُ عَمَلَ عَامِلٍ مِّنكُم

"I will not let the work of any of you go to waste" (3:195).

With thanks to my dear brother Syed Ahmed Hussaini, who first shared this with me.

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